

Essential vocabulary for travelling in Italy

A guide by Morgan · @italianwithmorgan

I am Italian. I grew up speaking this language at the table, in the street, at the bar. I know exactly which words you need when you land in Italy and which ones you'll never use. This guide is not a textbook. It's what I would tell a friend before their first trip.

In this guide

At the bar

Surviving your morning order without embarrassing yourself.

p.2

At the restaurant

From the menu to the bill, and how to avoid the traps.

p.2

In the street

Asking for directions when Google Maps has no signal.

p.3

At the hotel

Check-in, problems, and everything in between.

p.3

Transport

Trains, buses, taxis. Getting around without getting lost.

p.4

Market and shopping

Talking to vendors like a local.

p.4

False friends

Words that look like English but are not.

p.5

Useful expressions

What people actually say. Not what the manual says.

p.5

Culture and proverbs

Italian realities nobody explains.

p.6

At the bar

Surviving your morning order without embarrassing yourself

Un caffè means an espresso. Nobody says "un espresso" because it sounds like a tourist. Just say "un caffè" and you're fine.

Un caffè	/oon KAF-fè/	An espresso
"Un caffè, per favore."		"A coffee, please."
Un cappuccino	/kap-poo-CHEE-no/	A cappuccino
"Solo al mattino, non dopo pranzo."		"Morning only. Never after lunch."
Un caffè latte	/kaf-fè LAT-te/	A caffè latte
"Se dici "un latte" ti portano un bicchiere di latte."		"Say "un latte" and they bring you a glass of milk."
Un cornetto	/kor-NET-to/	A croissant
"Con la crema, per favore."		"With cream, please."
Il conto	/eel KON-to/	The bill
"Posso avere il conto?"		"Can I have the bill?"
Quanto costa?	/KWAN-to KOS-ta/	How much is it?
"Quanto costa in tutto?"		"How much in total?"

Standing at the counter is cheaper than sitting. That's how Italians do it.

At the restaurant

From the menu to the bill, and how to avoid the traps

The coperto (1-3 euros) appears on your bill automatically. It is for the bread and the tablecloth, not a tip. It's normal, don't argue.

Vorrei...	/vor-REI/	I would like...
"Vorrei una pizza margherita."		"I would like a margherita pizza."
Posso vedere il menù?	/me-NÙ/	Can I see the menu?
Il primo / secondo	/PREE-mo/	Starter / main

<i>"Prendo solo un primo."</i>		<i>"Just the starter for me."</i>
Il contorno	/kon-TOR-no/	Side dish
<i>"Un contorno di verdure."</i>		<i>"A vegetable side dish."</i>
Senza...	/SEN-tsa/	Without...
<i>"Senza aglio, per favore."</i>		<i>"Without garlic, please."</i>
Sono allergico/a a...	/al-LER-ji-ko/	I'm allergic to...
<i>"Sono allergico alle arachidi."</i>		<i>"I'm allergic to peanuts."</i>
È incluso il servizio?	/ser-VEE-tsio/	Is service included?
Il conto, per favore	/KON-to/	The bill please
<i>"Quando è pronto, il conto."</i>		<i>"Whenever you're ready, the bill."</i>

Tipping is not mandatory. 1-2 euros in cash is appreciated but nobody expects it.

In the street

Asking for directions when Google Maps has no signal

Scusi, dov'è...?	/SKU-zi/	Excuse me, where is...?
"Scusi, dov'è la fermata?"		"Excuse me, where is the stop?"
A destra / sinistra	/DES-tra / si-NIS-tra/	Right / left
"Gira a destra al semaforo."		"Turn right at the traffic lights."
Sempre dritto	/SEM-pre DRIT-to/	Straight ahead
"Vai sempre dritto."		"Go straight ahead."
È lontano?	/è lon-TA-no/	Is it far?
"Si può andare a piedi?"		"Can we walk there?"
A piedi / in macchina	/PIE-di/	On foot / by car

If you don't understand the answer, say "Può ripetere lentamente?" It works every time.

At the hotel

Check-in, problems, and everything in between

Ho una prenotazione	/pre-no-ta-TSYO-ne/	I have a reservation
"Ho una prenotazione a nome mio."		"I have a reservation in my name."
A che ora è il check-out?		What time is check-out?
La colazione è inclusa?	/ko-la-TSYO-ne/	Is breakfast included?
C'è il wifi?		Is there wifi?
"Qual è la password?"		"What's the password?"
C'è un problema	/pro-BLE-ma/	There's a problem
"C'è un problema con la doccia."		"There's a problem with the shower."
Posso lasciare i bagagli?	/ba-GA-li/	Can I leave my bags?
"Fino alle 18?"		"Until 6pm?"

In small B&Bs,, owners often speak very little English. Two sentences in Italian change everything.

Transport

Trains, buses, taxis. Getting around without getting lost

Validate your ticket before boarding on the orange machine on the platform. No validation means a fine, even if the train is empty.

Un biglietto per...	/bi-LIE-to/	A ticket to...
"Un biglietto per Firenze."		"A ticket to Florence."
Il binario	/bi-NA-rio/	The platform
"Da quale binario parte?"		"Which platform does it leave from?"
Il ritardo	/ri-TAR-do/	The delay
"C'è un ritardo?"		"Is there a delay?"
Andata e ritorno	/an-DA-ta/	Return ticket
"Solo andata, grazie."		"Single, thanks."
A che ora parte?	/PAR-te/	What time does it leave?
"E arriva?"		"And arrive?"
Può chiamarmi un taxi?		Can you call me a taxi?

Market and shopping

Talking to vendors like a local

At the market, try a few words. Vendors love it. Even badly pronounced. Especially badly pronounced.

Quanto viene?	/KWAN-to VIE-ne/	How much is it?
"Quanto viene in tutto?"		"How much in total?"
Un etto	/oon ET-to/	100 grams
"Un etto di prosciutto."		"100 grams of ham."
Mezzo chilo	/MET-zo KEE-lo/	500 grams
"Mezzo chilo di pomodori."		"500 grams of tomatoes."
Un po' di più / meno		A little more / less

"Un po' di più, grazie."	"A little more, thanks."
È fresco?	/è FRES-ko/ Is it fresh?
"Di oggi?"	"From today?"
Lo prendo.	/lo PREN-do/ I'll take it.
"Va bene, lo prendo."	"Alright, I'll take it."
Accettate la carta?	Do you take cards?
"Solo contanti?"	"Cash only?"

Numbers

1 — uno	2 — due
3 — tre	4 — quattro
5 — cinque	6 — sei
7 — sette	8 — otto
9 — nove	10 — dieci
20 — venti	50 — cinquanta
100 — cento	1000 — mille

False friends

Words that look like English but are not

These mistakes everyone makes once. Read this now so you don't make them in Italy.

Preservativo	not: preservative	condom. For preservative say "conservante".
Annoiato	not: annoyed	bored. Annoyed = infastidito.
Morbido	not: morbid	soft, gentle. Morbid = macabro.
Sensibile	not: sensible	sensitive (emotional). Sensible = ragionevole.
Attualmente	not: actually	right now. Actually = in realtà.
Eventualmente	not: eventually	if necessary. Eventually = prima o poi.

Emergencies

The phrases that really matter

Aiuto!	/a-YOO-to/	Help!
"Aiuto, ho bisogno di aiuto!"		"Help, I need help!"
Chiami un medico!	/KYA-mi/	Call a doctor!
"O un'ambulanza."		"Or an ambulance."
Ho perso...	/HO PER-zo/	I've lost...
"Ho perso il portafoglio."		"I've lost my wallet."
Dov'è il commissariato?		Where is the police station?
Non mi sento bene		I don't feel well

What people actually say

Non capisco.	I don't understand.
Può ripetere lentamente?	Can you repeat slowly?
Come si dice... in italiano?	How do you say... in Italian?
Non parlo bene l'italiano.	I don't speak Italian well.

<i>Scusa! / Scusi!</i>	Sorry! / Excuse me!
<i>Grazie mille!</i>	Thank you so much!
<i>Figurati!</i>	No problem at all. The natural reply to grazie.
<i>Mamma mia!</i>	Oh my god. Surprise, admiration, frustration. All of the above.
<i>Dai!</i>	Come on. No way. Really. Depends entirely on the tone.
<i>In bocca al lupo!</i>	Good luck. Reply with Crepi!

Some Italian realities

What nobody explains, but you'll see everywhere

Italy runs on unwritten rules. Nobody explains them because everyone knows them. Except you.

Cappuccino after 11am is not done. After a meal it's an espresso. Full stop.

Gestures are part of the language. "Che vuoi?" with the hand like a bunch of flowers means "What do you want?" You'll see it everywhere.

Don't ask for parmesan on seafood pasta. Italians notice.

Between 1pm and 3:30pm many shops close. Outside major tourist cities, plan accordingly.

"Ciao" with someone you don't know can seem abrupt. Start with "Buongiorno". Then you move to ciao.

Some small bars and markets don't take cards. Always keep a little cash.

Three proverbs to impress in conversation

"A tavola non si invecchia."

"You don't age at the table." The official excuse for any long meal.

"Chi dorme non piglia pesci."

"He who sleeps catches no fish."

"Paese che vai, usanza che trovi."

"Every country has its customs."



Want to go further?

I am Italian. I teach Italian. And I know that the difference between surviving in Italy and actually living it is one thing: knowing how people really speak. I offer 1:1 lessons. We start from where you are.

Instagram

[@italianwithmorgan](#)

Videos, culture, vocabulary. Several times a week.

Website

[italianwithmorgan.com](#)

My method, my plans, everything is there.

Book a lesson

[25 minutes free](#)

We talk, I understand where you are, we go from there.

"L'italiano non si studia — si ama." · Morgan · @italianwithmorgan